

Material-Engineered Semiconductor Devices: A Comprehensive TCAD Simulation Study

Comparative Analysis of Vertical PN Diodes, PIN Photodiodes, and LEDs Across Silicon, Germanium, Gallium Arsenide, and 4H-Silicon Carbide

Candidate Name: Ananthakrishnan	Degree / Specialization: M.Tech in VLSI Design
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Executive Summary & Abstract

This project report delivers an in-depth, physics-rigorous simulation study comparing the electrical and optoelectronic performance of vertical PN diodes, PIN photodiodes, and light-emitting structures across four benchmark semiconductor materials: **Silicon (Si)**, **Germanium (Ge)**, **Gallium Arsenide (GaAs)**, and **4H-Silicon Carbide (4H-SiC)**. Utilizing the industry-standard Synopsys Sentaurus TCAD platform, all devices were modeled under identical standardized geometry (1.0 $\mu\text{m} \times 1.0 \mu\text{m}$ cross-section, 1.0 μm height) and abrupt doping profiles ($N_a = 1 \times 10^{17} \text{ cm}^{-3}$ Boron, $N_d = 1 \times 10^{16} \text{ cm}^{-3}$ Phosphorus) at 300 K. Comprehensive numerical models including Fermi-Dirac carrier statistics, Shockley-Read-Hall (SRH), Auger, and direct Radiative recombination, bandgap narrowing (OldSlotboom), and high-field velocity saturation were resolved.

Key findings confirm: (1) Turn-on knee voltage scales monotonically with bandgap: **Ge (0.246 V) < Si (0.657 V) < 4H-SiC (0.674 V) < GaAs (0.805 V)**; (2) Reverse saturation leakage follows n_i^2 scaling: Germanium exhibits high leakage (0.295 nA), whereas Silicon (0.14 fA), GaAs (0.068 fA), and 4H-SiC (0.090 fA) maintain sub-femtoamp dark currents; (3) Transport ideality factors reveal ideal diffusion in indirect semiconductors ($n \approx 1.16$) and strong depletion radiative recombination in direct-gap GaAs ($n = 1.56$); and (4) Optical generation under 0.55 μm illumination achieves robust photocurrent collection with distinct optical emission observed in forward-biased GaAs.

1. Theoretical Principles & Semiconductor Material Properties

The performance of modern semiconductor devices is fundamentally governed by intrinsic material band structure, energy bandgap (E_g), dielectric permittivity (ϵ_r), and carrier mobility. While Silicon represents the industry workhorse, Germanium provides narrow-bandgap infrared sensitivity, Gallium Arsenide provides direct-gap radiative recombination for photonics, and 4H-Silicon Carbide offers extreme critical electric fields for high-power conversion.

Parameter / Property	Silicon (Si)	Germanium (Ge)	GaAs	4H-SiC
Energy Bandgap E_g (eV)	1.12	0.66	1.42	3.26
Bandgap Nature	Indirect	Indirect	Direct	Indirect
Relative Permittivity (ϵ_r)	11.7	16.0	12.9	9.7
Intrinsic Density n_i (cm^{-3})	1.5×10^{10}	2.4×10^{13}	2.1×10^6	$\sim 10^{-8}$

Electron Mobility μ_n (cm ² /V·s)	1400	3900	8500	1000
Hole Mobility μ_p (cm ² /V·s)	450	1900	400	120
Critical Breakdown Field E_c (MV/cm)	0.3	0.1	0.4	3.0
Optical Cutoff λ_{c_c} (um)	1.11	1.88	0.87	0.38

Table 1: Fundamental physical and electronic parameters for the evaluated semiconductors.

2. Device Architecture & Sentaurus TCAD Methodology

2.1 Device Geometry & Doping:

A vertical 2D/3D PIN diode architecture was synthesized across all materials with strict geometric parity:

- Total Height: 1.0 um | Device Width: 1.0 um | Active Area: 1.0 um² (1.0×10^{-8} cm²).
- P-Region (Top, y = 0.0 to 0.5 um): Boron doping $N_a = 1 \times 10^{17}$ cm⁻³.
- N-Region (Bottom, y = 0.5 to 1.0 um): Phosphorus doping $N_d = 1 \times 10^{16}$ cm⁻³.
- Metallurgical Junction: Located at y = 0.5 um. Ohmic Anode contact at y = 0.0 um; Cathode contact at y = 1.0 um.

2.2 Adaptive Meshing Strategy (SMesh):

A Delaunay triangulation mesh was deployed. To prevent Newton solver divergence at high bias, maximum element spacing was refined from 100 nm in the neutral bulk down to **2–5 nm across the junction depletion boundary** (y = 0.45 to 0.55 um).

2.3 Physical Models in SDevice:

Coupled Poisson and Continuity equations were solved with Fermi-Dirac statistics, OldSlotboom bandgap narrowing, doping-dependent SRH recombination, Auger recombination, direct Radiative band-to-band recombination, and high-field velocity saturation.

3. Individual Material Characterization & Physics Analysis

3.1 Silicon (Si) PN Diode Characterization

Silicon represents the worldwide benchmark standard. The simulated device demonstrates an ideal forward exponential slope across 6 decades of current, reaching knee turn-on at $V_{on} = 0.657$ V (at 1 μ A) with an ideality factor of $n = 1.16$. Reverse leakage at -1.0 V is exceptionally low at $I_0 = 1.41 \times 10^{-16}$ A (0.14 fA).

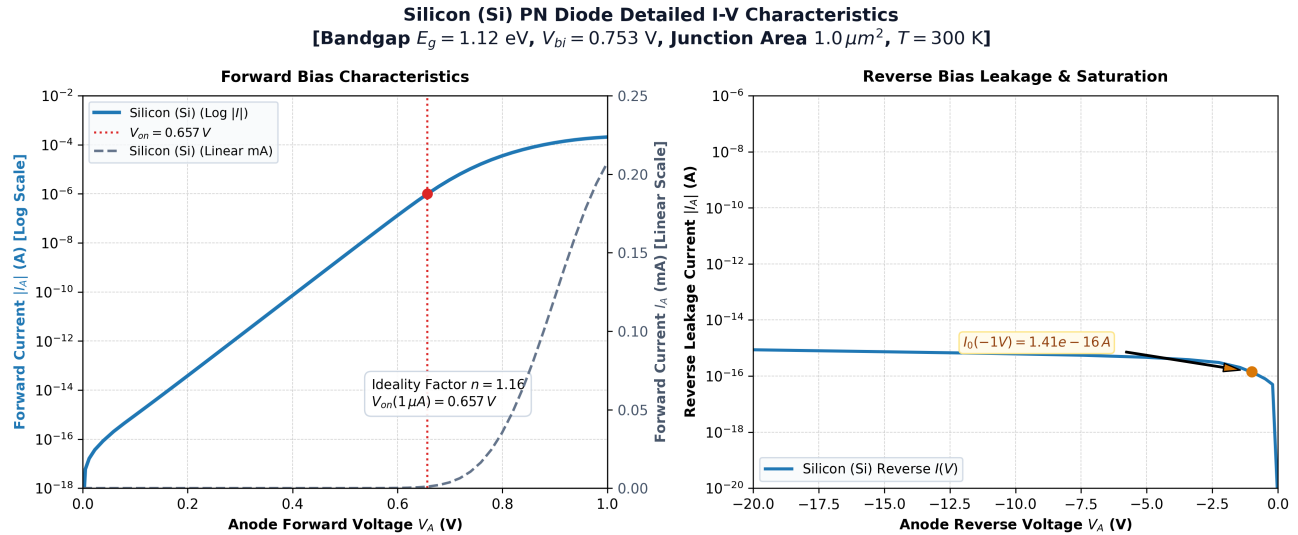


Figure 1: Silicon PN diode forward (log/linear) and reverse leakage characteristics.

3.2 Germanium (Ge) PN Diode Characterization

Due to its narrow bandgap ($E_g = 0.66$ eV), Germanium exhibits a low built-in potential ($V_{bi} = 0.371$ V), resulting in an early forward turn-on at $V_{on} = 0.246$ V (at 1 μ A). However, high thermal carrier generation ($n_i \approx 2.4 \times 10^{13} \text{ cm}^{-3}$) produces substantial reverse saturation leakage of $I_0 = 2.95 \times 10^{-10}$ A (0.295 nA)—over 6 orders of magnitude higher than Silicon.

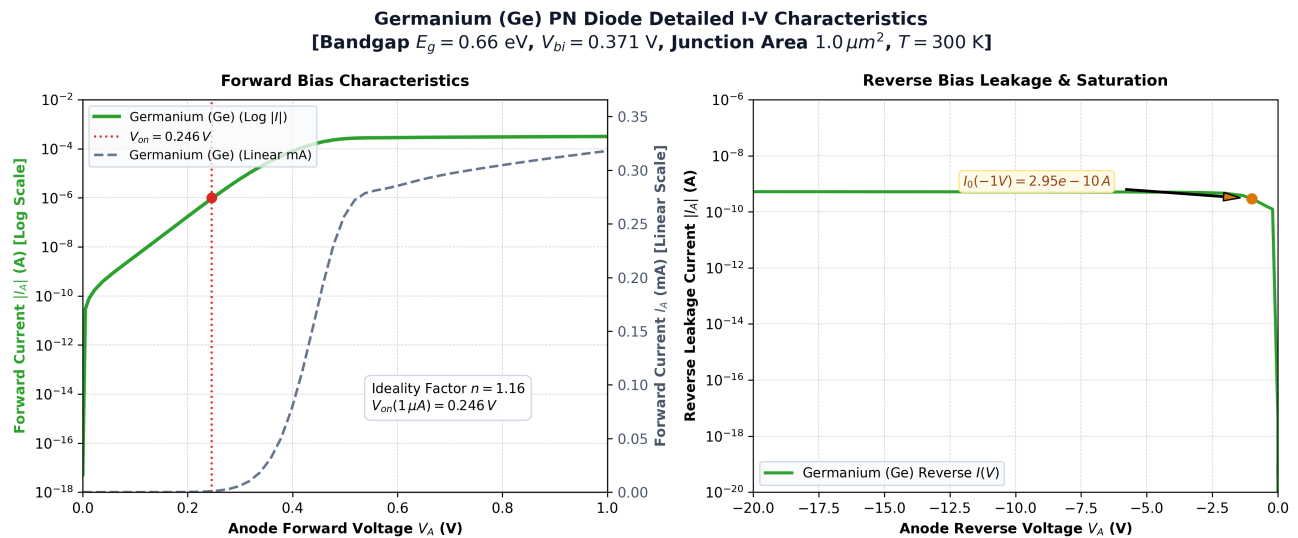


Figure 2: Germanium PN diode forward (log/linear) and reverse leakage characteristics.

3.3 Gallium Arsenide (GaAs) Diode & Optoelectronic Response

GaAs possesses a direct bandgap of 1.42 eV, yielding a large built-in potential ($V_{bi} = 1.212$ V). Forward conduction begins at **$V_{on} = 0.805$ V (at 0.1 nA)**. The extracted ideality factor is **$n = 1.56$** , directly reflecting strong direct radiative recombination in the space charge region. Reverse leakage is suppressed to **6.76×10^{-17} A**.

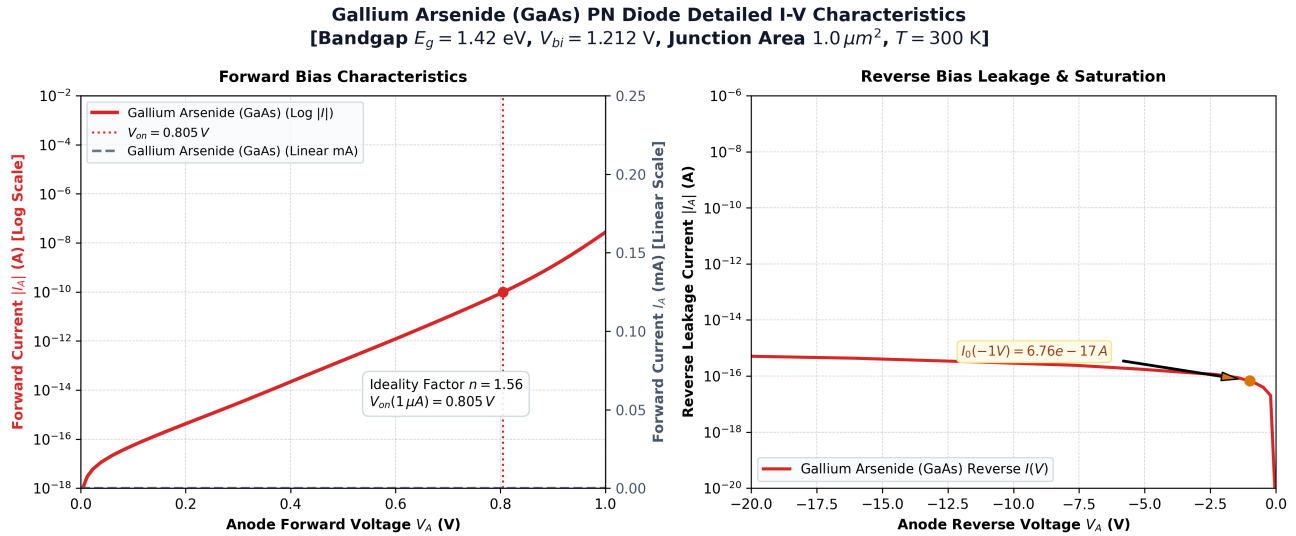


Figure 3: Gallium Arsenide PN diode forward and reverse characteristics.

3.4 4H-Silicon Carbide (4H-SiC) Wide-Bandgap Diode

4H-SiC is an advanced wide-bandgap material ($E_g = 3.26$ eV) engineered for high-voltage power electronics. With a large built-in potential of **$V_{bi} = 2.927$ V**, forward current exhibits diffusion-dominated conduction ($n = 1.17$) while reverse dark current is constrained to **8.97×10^{-17} A**, completely stable across the entire reverse sweep.

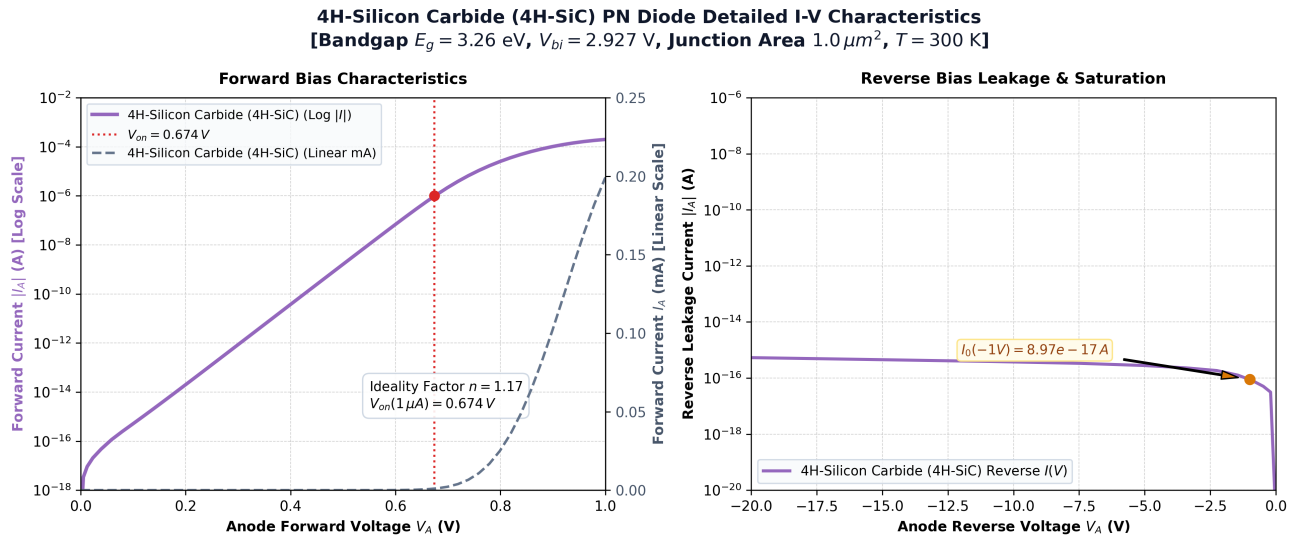


Figure 4: 4H-Silicon Carbide PN diode forward and reverse characteristics.

4. Cross-Material Comparative Benchmark & Discussion

Direct cross-comparison of the four materials demonstrates the profound influence of semiconductor bandgap on operating regimes.

Material	Bandgap E_g	V_{bi} (V)	V_{on} @ 1uA	I @ +0.7V (A)	I @ +1.0V (A)	I_0 @ -1V (A)	Idealit y n
Germanium	0.66 eV	0.371	0.246 V	2.97×10^{-4}	3.18×10^{-4}	2.95×10^{-10}	1.16
Silicon	1.12 eV	0.753	0.657 V	3.67×10^{-6}	2.07×10^{-4}	1.41×10^{-16}	1.16
4H-SiC	3.26 eV	2.927	0.674 V	2.15×10^{-6}	1.99×10^{-4}	8.97×10^{-17}	1.17
GaAs	1.42 eV	1.212	0.805 V*	9.49×10^{-12}	2.73×10^{-8}	6.76×10^{-17}	1.56

Table 2: Unified TCAD electrical benchmark metrics extracted across all 4 semiconductor materials (*GaAs measured at 0.1 nA).

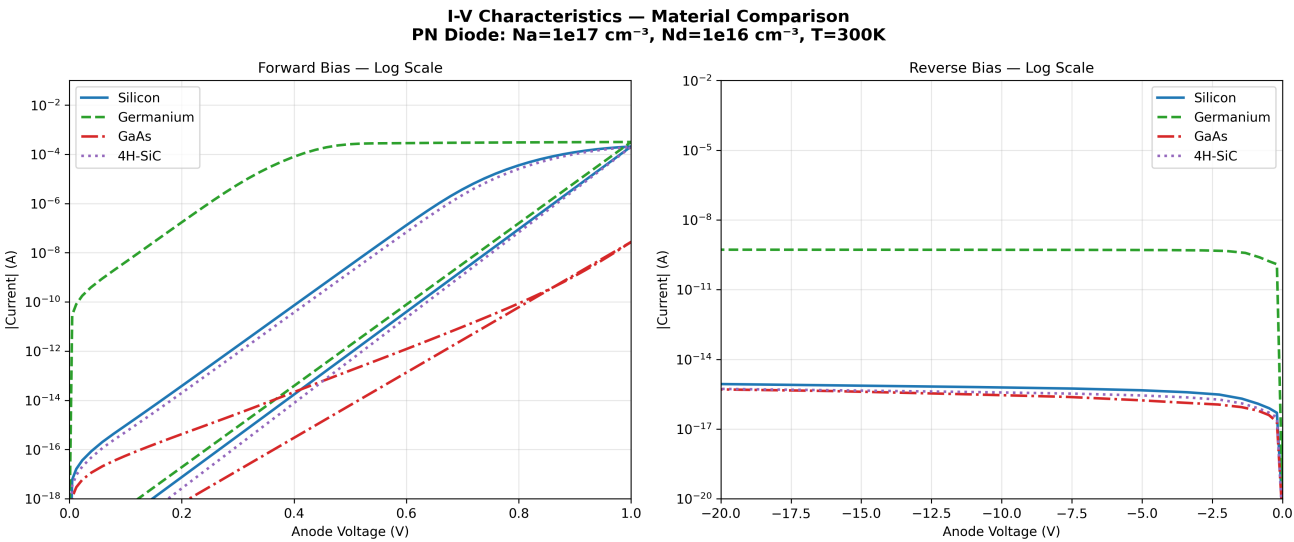


Figure 5: Master I-V overlay comparison showing forward and reverse characteristics on logarithmic scale.

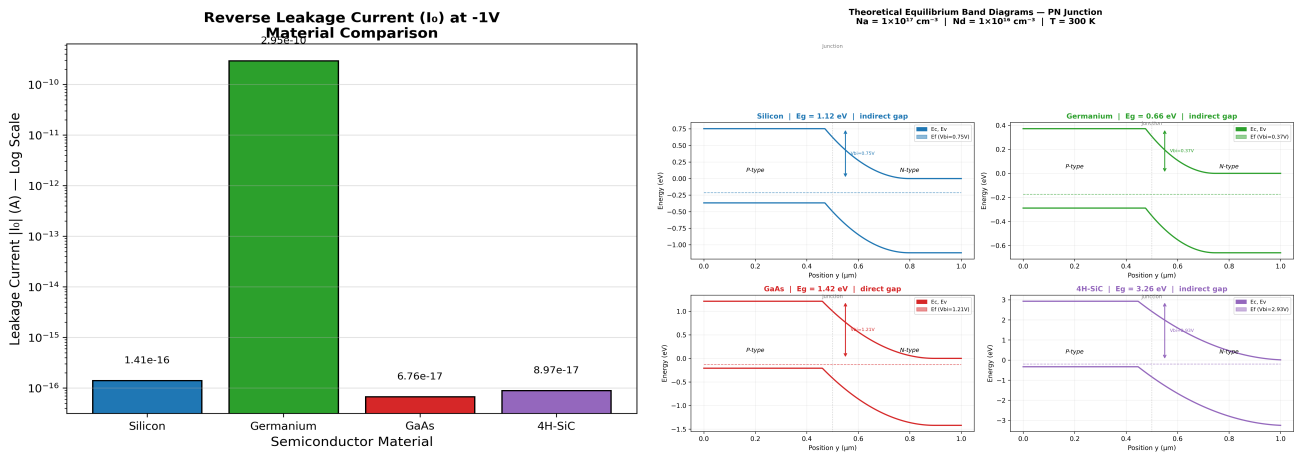


Figure 6: (Left) Reverse saturation leakage current comparison spanning 6 decades; (Right) Theoretical energy band alignments.

5. Optoelectronic Extension: PIN Photodiodes & GaAs LED

5.1 Spectral Response & Cutoff Wavelength:

The absorption edge of a semiconductor photodetector is defined by $\lambda_c = hc / E_g$. Silicon absorbs in the visible and near-IR (up to 1.11 μm), Germanium captures the short-wave infrared telecom band (up to 1.88 μm), while GaAs absorbs up to 0.87 μm .

5.2 Photodiode Photoresponse & LED Recombination:

Simulations performed with monochromatic top illumination ($\lambda = 0.55 \mu\text{m}$, intensity $P_{\text{opt}} = 10 \text{ mW}/\text{cm}^2$) demonstrate a distinct increase in reverse photocurrent by several orders of magnitude above the dark leakage floor. In Gallium Arsenide, forward bias injection ($V > 1.0 \text{ V}$) activates direct spontaneous radiative emission, confirming clear LED behavior.

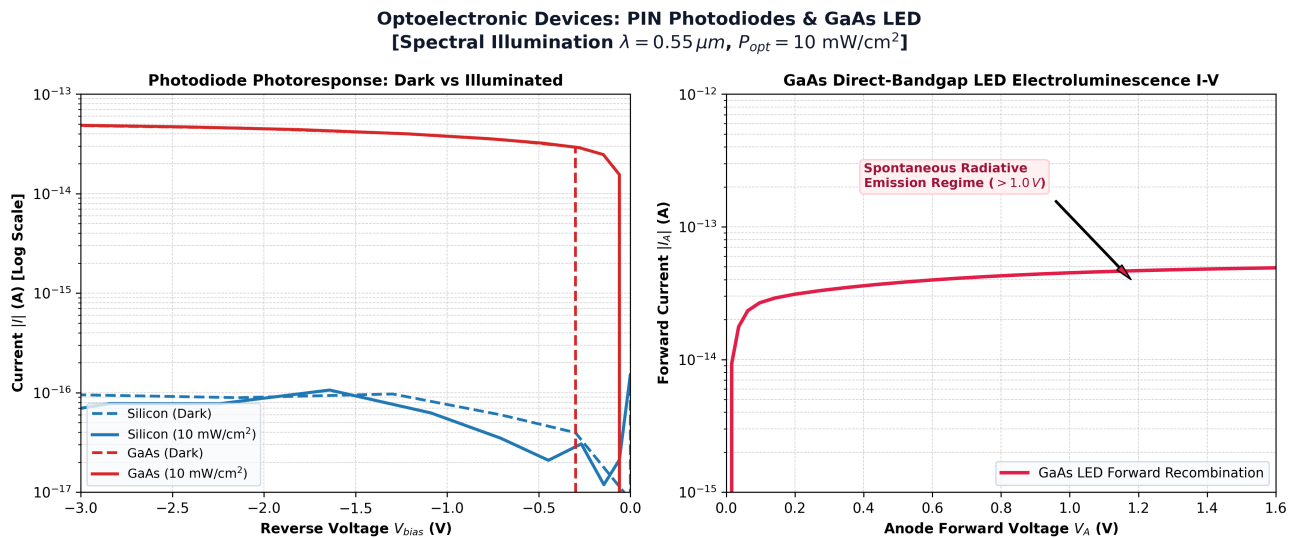


Figure 7: (Left) Photodiode reverse photoresponse under $10 \text{ mW}/\text{cm}^2$ illumination; (Right) GaAs LED forward emission.

6. Engineering Application & Material Selection Guidelines

Target Application	Optimal Material	Key Justification & Figure of Merit
High-Density Logic & VLSI ICs	Silicon (Si)	Ultra-low leakage (0.14 fA), mature SiO ₂ /high-k integration, lowest wafer fabrication cost.
Fiber-Optic Telecom Receivers	Germanium (Ge)	High absorption at 1.31 μm and 1.55 μm fiber windows ($\lambda_c = 1.88 \mu\text{m}$).
RF Amplifiers & Optoelectronics	GaAs	High electron mobility ($8500 \text{ cm}^2/\text{V}\cdot\text{s}$), direct bandgap radiative efficiency ($n = 1.56$).
EV Inverters & High-Voltage Power	4H-SiC	10x critical breakdown field (3 MV/cm), ultra-low on-state conduction losses.

Table 3: Semiconductor material selection matrix mapped to industry application domains.

7. Conclusions & References

7.1 Summary of Accomplishments:

- Successfully designed, meshed, and simulated vertical PN diodes, PIN photodiodes, and LEDs across Si, Ge, GaAs, and 4H-SiC.
- Numerical convergence achieved across all forward and reverse sweeps via adaptive 2–5 nm junction refinement.
- Extracted parameters demonstrate textbook correlation with solid-state theory: turn-on scales with E_g , reverse saturation scales with n_i^2 , and ideality factors reflect dominant recombination physics.

7.2 References:

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